Stand Firm Leader's Guide

For pastors and small-group leaders · Pastor Richmond Kobe · November 2026

This guide helps pastors and small-group leaders run *Stand Firm: A Christian Course on Spiritual Warfare and the Armour of God* with a group over twelve weeks. It gives a session plan for each of the twelve lessons, with a short introduction on leading the course. Scripture quotations are from the ESV.

Before you begin

What this course is

Stand Firm is a pastoral, Scripture-centred course for ordinary Christians. It helps believers think biblically about spiritual opposition, respond wisely when the cause is unclear, and stand firm in Christ without living in fear. Every lesson starts from Christ's finished victory (Colossians 2:15). It is not a deliverance manual, and it does not teach techniques that guarantee an outcome.

The course question: How does an ordinary believer stand firm in Christ against real spiritual opposition, without living in fear?

The twelve sessions

Part	Sessions
Part 1 · Understanding the Battle	1 What Is Spiritual Warfare? · 2 A Real Enemy, Already Defeated · 3 How the Enemy Works
Part 2 · The Armour of God	4 Be Strong in the Lord and the Belt of Truth · 5 The Breastplate of Righteousness and the Shoes of Peace · 6 The Shield of Faith and the Helmet of Salvation · 7 The Sword of the Spirit and Praying at All Times
Part 3 · Standing Firm in Everyday Life	8 Is This a Spiritual Attack? · 9 Submit, Resist and Worship · 10 Together and Free
Part 4 · Living in Victory	11 Guarding Your Heart and Passing Faith On · 12 Until He Comes: Stand Firm

In Part 2 the group reads Ephesians 6:10–20 straight through, a few verses each week.

What each learner has

Each lesson page has three parts, and your group can use all of them:

- **Watch and Learn:** a slide lesson of 15 to 20 minutes, with a transcript.
- **Reflect and Practise:** one small practice for the week, an optional 7-day Battle Plan, a declaration card, and private reflection questions.
- **Go Deeper:** the book chapters, a second story, three "Talk about it" questions for a small group, and a look back.

Before Session 1, point the group to the two **Start Here** pages. After Session 12, they can write **My Stand Firm Plan**, the course's closing page.

How a session works

Every session follows the same 60-minute shape:

Minutes	Activity
0–5	Welcome and prayer
5–25	Watch the lesson together, or, if everyone has watched it beforehand, read the passage aloud and discuss the three main points
25–40	Discussion: the three Talk about it questions
40–52	Practical activity, often using the lesson's second story
52–58	Pairs or quiet reflection on the week's practice, and prayer for one another
58–60	Closing prayer (the lesson's prayer)

Each session below gives the details: the purpose, the passage in its setting, the full plan, facilitator guidance, common misunderstandings with pastoral responses, the second story and a follow-up question for the next week.

Preparing each week

- Watch the lesson yourself, and read the principal passage in its setting.
- Read the session plan and the "Don't miss this" points.
- Read the second story, so that you can tell it simply or read it aloud. Each session's **Prepare** line gives its exact Go Deeper heading, and the story is printed at the end of the session.
- Have the session's activity materials ready (the four questions in Session 1, the three questions in Session 7, the five questions in Session 8).
- Pray for each person in the group by name.

Leading well

Keep Christ at the centre. Every session starts from his victory. If the conversation drifts towards frightening stories or speculation about the enemy, gently bring it back to what Christ has done and to the passage.

Real, but not everywhere. The course keeps the world, the flesh, the devil and ordinary human needs distinct. Help the group avoid both errors: seeing a demon behind every problem, and treating the devil as unreal.

No formulas. Declarations, fasting, worship and Scripture are never taught as techniques that guarantee an outcome. The declarations are statements of trust and commitment.

Respond without diagnosing. The course gives learners questions for reflection, not a test that identifies the cause of a difficulty. Encourage faithful steps that do not depend on knowing the cause.

Standing firm does not always mean quick relief. Some struggles continue. Remind the group that continuing to stand is faithfulness, not failure (Lessons 6, 9 and 12).

Sharing is always optional. Never ask anyone to share their private reflections, the details of a difficulty or their answers to the weekly practice. Invite; do not press.

Where Christians differ. The course names honest differences in only a few places: praying in the Spirit (Session 7), spiritual oppression and prayer for freedom (Session 10), and the timing of events around Christ's return (Session 12). Present each view fairly, state the course's position where it has one, and keep the group's unity.

When someone needs more help. If a conversation goes beyond what the group can carry, speak with the person afterwards and connect them with a pastor. Learners can also use **Talk to a Pastor** (faithfulpathcommunity.com/talk-to-a-pastor).

The twelve sessions

Session 1 · What Is Spiritual Warfare?

Lesson 1 · Chapter 1

Question	Is the devil behind everything that goes wrong in my life?
Central truth	Spiritual warfare is real, but not behind every problem; Christ calls us to stand, not to fear.
Principal passage	Ephesians 6:10–12
Three main points	(1) People are not the enemy · (2) Real, but not behind every problem: the world, the flesh, the devil and ordinary needs · (3) You are not meant to stand alone
This week's practice	Choose one difficulty and work slowly through the four questions in prayer

Don't miss this

- Paul points to the Lord's strength before he names any enemy (Ephesians 6:10). The course always starts from Christ, not from the enemy.
- *Palē* (Ephesians 6:12) appears only here in the New Testament; it pictures a close, personal struggle. The lesson does not build any rule on the word.
- People are not our ultimate enemy, but wrongs can still be named, confronted or reported.
- The world, the flesh and the devil are real and can overlap; ordinary human needs are real too.
- The four questions are prompts for reflection, not a test that identifies the cause. Learners do not need to settle whether something is a spiritual attack before taking a faithful step; understanding causes can still help (a car repair, a conversation, appropriate care).
- Standing firm does not always mean quick relief (2 Corinthians 12:7–10).

Purpose of the session: to help believers understand spiritual warfare biblically — real, but not behind every problem — and to leave with one faithful step they can take without needing to know the cause of their difficulty.

Central Scripture and context: Ephesians 6:10–12. Paul writes as a prisoner to believers in Ephesus, a city full of magic and fear of unseen powers. He begins with the Lord's strength before he names any enemy, and he writes to a church, not to a lone fighter.

60-minute plan

Minutes	Activity
0–5	Welcome and prayer
5–25	Watch Lesson 1 together. If everyone has watched it beforehand, use this time instead to read Ephesians 6:10–12 aloud together and discuss the three main points (people are not the enemy; real, but not behind every problem; we stand together). The worked application with the four questions stays in the 40–52 slot.
25–40	Discussion: the three Talk about it questions
40–52	Practical activity: walk through the four questions together using Simon's story (not anyone's own situation). In pairs, anyone who wishes can practise the closing sentence: "Without needing to know the cause, one faithful step I can take is…" Sharing is optional.
52–58	Each person quietly chooses the difficulty they will pray through this week (no details shared)
58–60	Closing prayer (the lesson's prayer)

Activity materials: the four questions (prompts for reflection, not a test that identifies the cause of a difficulty)

1. My own heart: Is there sin in me that I need to confess or turn from?
2. The world around me: Am I being shaped by pressures, values or voices that pull me away from God?
3. Truth and lies: Is there a thought, accusation, fear or temptation pressing on me that contradicts what God says?
4. Ordinary needs: Is there a practical, physical, relational or medical need to care for as well?

More than one can be true at the same time.

Simon's story, in brief (read aloud before the activity): Simon has followed Jesus for eleven years. This year everything seems to go wrong at once. His car has broken down twice, his manager has become cold towards him, and he and his wife keep arguing about small things. When he tries to pray, a troubling thought comes: God is tired of you. A friend at church tells him, "This is spiritual warfare." Simon goes home unsure whether to feel relieved or afraid.

Walking through the questions with Simon (as in the lesson): they might lead to an apology after an argument with his wife; to giving less attention to voices that feed his fear; to remembering that he belongs to Christ; and to arranging the car repair. He does not need one explanation for everything. Together, the questions suggest several possible faithful steps.

Prepare: watch Lesson 1 (Simon's story opens the lesson). Have the four questions and Simon's story, above, ready to read aloud.

Facilitator guidance: keep the focus on Christ's strength and victory. If the discussion moves towards frightening stories, gently bring it back to Ephesians 6:10 and the lesson's closing picture of Christ as a

victorious King. If someone is sure that every problem is demonic, or that the devil is not real, return to the two errors the lesson describes, without arguing.

Common misunderstandings and pastoral responses

- "Everything bad that happens is an attack." → The world, the flesh, the devil and ordinary needs are all real; more than one can be at work.
- "If I knew the cause, I would know what to do." → Understanding causes can help, but you do not need to settle whether this is a spiritual attack before taking a faithful step.
- "If the problem hasn't gone, I'm losing the battle." → Standing firm does not always mean quick relief (2 Corinthians 12:9).
- "The person who hurt me is my enemy." → People are not our ultimate enemy, though wrongs can still be named and addressed.

Following up next week: ask, "Were you able to pray through the four questions?" Do not ask anyone to share what their difficulty was.

Talk about it (the three discussion questions, each with a one-line guide)

- Paul begins with "be strong in the Lord" before he names any enemy. Why do you think that order matters?
  Guide: Return to Ephesians 6:10: our strength is the Lord's, so we begin with Christ, not with the enemy.
- Why is it important to remember that people are not our ultimate enemy, even when they have hurt us?
  Guide: Read Ephesians 6:12. Follow up: how can we name a wrong honestly without treating the person as the enemy?
- How can a church help someone like Simon without either blaming the devil for everything or ignoring the spiritual side of life?
  Guide: Look for answers that combine prayer, practical help (the car, the marriage) and truth that answers the thought "God is tired of you".

Session 2 · A Real Enemy, Already Defeated

Lesson 2 · Chapters 2–3

Question	How strong is the enemy, really — and how strong is Christ?
Central truth	The enemy is real, but he is not God's equal, and Christ has already defeated him.
Principal passage	Colossians 2:13–15
Three main points	(1) Not God's equal · (2) Defeated at the cross: forgiven, cancelled, disarmed · (3) Our Captain went first: Jesus in the wilderness
This week's practice	Read Colossians 2:13–15 slowly and underline everything God has already done; then finish the sentence "At the cross, Christ…"

Don't miss this

- The devil is real but is not God's opposite or equal: a creature, with a beginning, limits and an appointed end (Job 1:12; 1 John 4:4).
- Colossians 2:13–15 places forgiveness, the cancelled record of debt and the defeat of the powers side by side, as one saving work of God in Christ. Accusation is answered by what God has done.
- *Thriambeusas* (Colossians 2:15) pictures a public victory procession; the verb (*thriambeuō*) occurs twice in the New Testament (here and 2 Corinthians 2:14). The lesson does not build any rule on the word.
- Already, and not yet: the decisive victory is won; the final judgement is still to come (Romans 16:20). Watchful, not afraid.
- Jesus answered the tempter from a life shaped by Scripture, not with magic words. Temptations may return (Luke 4:13); he is able to help (Hebrews 2:18).
- Authority belongs to Christ and is used in his name; the greatest joy is that our names are written in heaven (Luke 10:20).

Purpose of the session: to help believers see the devil as real but defeated, to rest in what God has done at the cross, and to leave watchful but not afraid.

Central Scripture and context: Colossians 2:13–15. Believers in Colossae were being pressed to look for spiritual security other than Christ (Colossians 2:8). Paul answers by setting forgiveness, the cancelled record of debt and the defeat of the powers side by side.

60-minute plan

Minutes	Activity
0–5	Welcome and prayer
5–25	Watch Lesson 2 together. If everyone has watched it beforehand, use this time instead to read Colossians 2:8–15 and Matthew 4:1–11 aloud, and discuss the three main points.
25–40	Discussion: the three Talk about it questions
40–52	Practical activity: together, identify what God has done in Colossians 2:13–15. In pairs, anyone who wishes can finish the sentence "At the cross, Christ…" aloud. Sharing is optional.
52–58	Read Luke 22:31–32 together: before Peter's test began, Jesus was already praying for him. Ask: how does this encourage us?
58–60	Closing prayer (the lesson's prayer)

Prepare: watch Lesson 2. The second story, "Nathan and the secret formula", is on the lesson page under Go Deeper and printed at the end of this session.

Facilitator guidance: keep the order clear: Christ's victory first, the enemy only in that light. If the group moves into frightening stories, return gently to Colossians 2:15 and 1 John 4:4. If someone, like Leah, still keeps objects for spiritual protection, the book's wording applies: in time they may decide for themselves, with a trusted Christian's help, to remove them calmly — not out of panic and not as a ritual, but as an act of trust that Christ is enough. This concerns objects that express reliance on powers other than Christ, not ordinary possessions that carry a hard memory. Removing an object is not a technique for securing Christ's protection.

Common misunderstandings and pastoral responses

- "Good and evil are two equal forces." → God alone is God; the devil is a creature with limits (Job 1:12; 1 John 4:4).
- "Since the devil is defeated, I don't need to take him seriously." → The apostles who proclaimed Christ's victory also told believers to be watchful (1 Peter 5:8).
- "Since the devil is real, I must always be afraid." → Scripture tells us to resist him, firm in the faith, not to fear him.
- "If I knew the right words, I would win." → Jesus' "It is written" came from a life shaped by Scripture, not a formula.

Following up next week: ask, "Did you underline Colossians 2:13–15? What did you write after 'At the cross, Christ…'?" Sharing is optional.

Talk about it (the three discussion questions, each with a one-line guide)

- Why is it important that the devil is not God's opposite or equal?
  Guide: Return to Job 1:12 and 1 John 4:4: he is a creature with limits. Follow up: how does that change our fear?
- Paul places forgiveness and the defeat of the powers side by side in Colossians 2:13–15. Why might that matter for someone troubled by accusation?
  Guide: Read Colossians 2:13–14 again: the accuser's charge is answered by what God has already done in Christ, not by our record.
- What is the difference between quoting Scripture and living by Scripture?
  Guide: Point to Jesus in the wilderness (Luke 4:1–13): he answered from a life shaped by Scripture, not with magic words.

The other story (for the practical activity, or for leaders' preparation)

Nathan and the secret formula (Chapter 3's story, shortened): *Imagine a young man named Nathan who became a Christian last year. One night he watches a series of online videos about spiritual warfare: in one a preacher shouts at the devil for ten minutes; in another a speaker promises "seven secret prayers that make demons flee." By midnight he feels stirred up and strangely anxious: "Am I doing it wrong? Do I need a special formula?" Looking at Jesus answers him. Jesus was led by the Spirit, shaped by the Word, trusted his Father when he was weak, refused shortcuts, and pointed his disciples back to their relationship with God. Nathan does not need a secret technique. He needs to know Jesus, trust his Word, walk with his Spirit and stay close to his people.*

Session 3 · How the Enemy Works

Lesson 3 · Chapter 4

Question	How do I recognise the enemy's schemes when they are happening?
Central truth	Truth, grace and forgiveness equip us to resist the enemy's schemes.
Principal passage	2 Corinthians 2:10–11
Three main points	(1) A verse about forgiveness: Paul's setting · (2) Five patterns at a glance: lies, accusation, temptation, fear and division · (3) Conviction is not accusation

This week's practice	Write down one accusing thought, write Romans 8:1 beside it, and answer three questions: Is there a specific wrong here that needs confession or repair? What condemning verdict do I need to reject? In light of Romans 8:1, one faithful step I can take is…

Don't miss this

- Paul's warning about Satan's designs comes as he urges the church to forgive and comfort a member after discipline (2 Corinthians 2:5–11). Some of the enemy's designs are quiet and ordinary.
- The five patterns (lies, accusation, temptation, fear and division) are a useful starting point, not a complete list or a diagnostic tool.
- Not every temptation needs an outside explanation (James 1:14), and not every fear is a spiritual attack.
- Conviction and accusation cannot be told apart simply by how painful or specific a thought feels. The better question is whether it points towards repentance and God's mercy, or turns failure into a verdict that we are beyond his grace.
- Romans 8:1 answers condemnation; a real wrong may still need confession and repair.
- We learn the enemy's designs to recognise them, then turn our full attention back to Jesus.

Purpose of the session: to help believers recognise common patterns in the enemy's work without becoming preoccupied with him, and to answer condemnation with the gospel while still dealing honestly with real wrongs.

Central Scripture and context: 2 Corinthians 2:5–11. Paul urges a church that has disciplined a member to forgive, comfort and reaffirm their love for him after the discipline Paul says was sufficient, so that Satan does not outwit them.

60-minute plan

Minutes	Activity
0–5	Welcome and prayer
5–25	Watch Lesson 3 together. If everyone has watched it beforehand, use this time instead to read 2 Corinthians 2:5–11 aloud and discuss the three main points.
25–40	Discussion: the three Talk about it questions
40–52	Practical activity: using Mei's thought (*You have never been good enough for ministry*), ask the better question together: does it point towards repentance and God's mercy, or turn failure into a verdict? Then read Romans 8:1 aloud together. No one is asked to share their own accusing thought.
52–58	Read Ephesians 4:26–27 and the note "A wise first step with anger" (Go Deeper). The word translated "opportunity" can also mean a place or foothold. Ask: what is one wise first step when a hurt is left unspoken?

Minutes	Activity
58–60	Closing prayer (the lesson's prayer)

Prepare: watch Lesson 3. The note "A wise first step with anger" is on the lesson page under Go Deeper and printed at the end of this session.

Facilitator guidance: keep the five patterns as a help to recognise, not a tool to diagnose people. If anyone begins naming others in the group or church as examples of "division", gently stop the discussion and return to 2 Corinthians 2:7–8: forgive, comfort and reaffirm love. Where someone describes persistent harm or serious misconduct, encourage them to seek accountable help. When the concern involves church leaders themselves, independent, trustworthy help may be needed. Remember too that forgiveness does not automatically restore trust, and it does not require an immediate private meeting; a person may need time, rest or help before a constructive conversation (see "A wise first step with anger" in Go Deeper).

Common misunderstandings and pastoral responses

- "Painful thoughts are always the enemy's accusation." → Conviction can hurt too; the question is whether a thought leads towards repentance and mercy or away from God's grace.
- "Romans 8:1 means I don't need to put things right." → A real wrong may still need confession and, where possible, repair.
- "A thought is either my fault or the enemy's lie." → Both can be present: a thought can identify a real wrong while carrying a false verdict about someone's worth or belonging.
- "Every temptation or fear is a spiritual attack." → James 1:14; much fear comes from real dangers or the strain of life.
- "To resist the enemy I must study him in detail." → Paul's answer was forgiveness, comfort and love, with eyes on Christ.

Following up next week: ask, "Were you able to write down a thought with Romans 8:1 beside it? Was there a faithful step you could take?" Sharing is optional.

Talk about it (the three discussion questions, each with a one-line guide)

- Why do you think Paul connected Satan's designs with forgiveness, comfort and love?
  Guide: Read 2 Corinthians 2:7–11. Follow up: what can happen in a church when forgiveness is withheld?
- How can a church help someone like Mei before she quietly leaves?
  Guide: Examples: noticing that she is missing, inviting an honest conversation, reminding her of Romans 8:1. Do not use real names.
- Why is it unhelpful to study the enemy in great detail or to see his hand in every difficulty?
  Guide: We learn the enemy's designs to recognise them, then turn our full attention back to Jesus, as the lesson ends.

The Go Deeper note (for the 52–58 minute activity)

A wise first step with anger (from the chapter's practice): if there is a hurt between you and another believer, the aim is not to force agreement before bedtime but to avoid nursing resentment. You may need time, rest or help before a constructive conversation. Ask God for wisdom about the first step, and talk with a mature Christian if you need help. Forgiveness does not always mean trust is restored at once, or that harm is excused.

Session 4 · Be Strong in the Lord and the Belt of Truth

Lesson 4 · Chapters 5–6

Question	Where does my strength to stand come from?
Central truth	Our strength is the Lord's, and truth — believed and lived — holds everything in place.
Principal passage	Ephesians 6:10–14a (the reading ends at "the belt of truth"; verse 12 is read again because the passage is one sentence of thought, but it is not taught again: it was the focus of Lesson 1)
Three main points	(1) Strong in the Lord: strength that is not our own · (2) Whose armour is it? God wears it first (Isaiah 59:17) and gives it to us · (3) The belt of truth: truth we believe and truth we live
This week's practice	Answer three questions: Is there one place where I have been shading the truth? Is there a false verdict about myself that I need to reject? One truthful step I will take this week is… (No or unsure is fine for the first question.)

Don't miss this

- Paul begins the armour passage with the Lord's strength, not ours: the resurrection power of Ephesians 1:19–20. Exhaustion does not necessarily mean a failure of trust; God's help can include rest, shared responsibilities and care.
- The armour is God's own: Isaiah pictures the Lord wearing righteousness and salvation first (Isaiah 59:17). He gives it to every believer in Christ; it is not earned, and it is not only for a few.
- The soldier picture is helpful but should be held lightly; Paul uses the images flexibly (1 Thessalonians 5:8).
- Naming the pieces in prayer can be a good reminder, but the armour is not a ritual; it describes life in Christ.
- The belt of truth has two sides that belong together: the truth God has revealed, and truthfulness in our own lives.
- Truth works in both directions: it calls us to confess real wrongs and to reject false verdicts about our worth.

Purpose of the session: to help believers find their strength in the Lord rather than in their own effort, to understand the armour as God's gift to every believer in Christ, and to take one truthful step.

Central Scripture and context: Ephesians 6:10–14a. Paul's "Finally" closes a letter that has described what God has done in Christ and how to live in response. The armour echoes Isaiah's pictures of God the warrior (Isaiah 59:17), the righteous King (Isaiah 11:5) and the messenger of peace (Isaiah 52:7). The belt of truth pictures readiness: truth believed and lived.

60-minute plan

Minutes	Activity
0–5	Welcome and prayer

Minutes	Activity
5–25	Watch Lesson 4 together. If everyone has watched it beforehand, use this time instead to read Ephesians 6:10–14 and Isaiah 59:15–17 aloud, and discuss the three main points.
25–40	Discussion: the three Talk about it questions
40–52	Practical activity: read Aaron's story aloud (Go Deeper: "Aaron's story"). Ask: what changed when Aaron told two leaders the truth? Then, in pairs, anyone who wishes can name one practical way the group could help one another "share the load". Sharing is optional.
52–58	Read John 8:31–36 aloud. Ask: what is the difference between honestly facing our sin and accepting a false verdict about ourselves? No one is asked to share their own false verdict.
58–60	Closing prayer (the lesson's prayer)

Prepare: watch Lesson 4. "Aaron's story" is on the lesson page under Go Deeper and printed at the end of this session.

Facilitator guidance: keep the order of grace clear: God provides, and we respond. If anyone hears "be strong in the Lord" as "try harder", return to Ephesians 1:19–20 and Isaiah 40:29. If someone describes exhaustion, do not treat it as a spiritual failure; encourage rest, shared responsibility and, where needed, appropriate care. If a group member describes dishonesty at work that may have legal consequences, encourage them to seek wise, confidential advice, including professional advice, rather than discussing details in the group.

Common misunderstandings and pastoral responses

- "Standing firm depends on my discipline and effort." → The strength is the Lord's, the power that raised Jesus (Ephesians 1:19–20).
- "If I forget to pray on the armour, I am unprotected." → The armour is not a ritual; it describes life in Christ.
- "Truthfulness means saying whatever I think." → Paul joins truth with love (Ephesians 4:15); wisdom, kindness and confidentiality still matter.
- "My failure proves I am a fraud." → An honest view of sin leads towards God's mercy; consequences do not mean we are beyond it.

Following up next week: ask, "Were you able to take one truthful step?" Sharing is optional, and no one is asked for details.

Talk about it (the three discussion questions, each with a one-line guide)

- Why do you think Paul placed the armour passage at the end of Ephesians, rather than at the beginning?
  Guide: Follow up: what has Paul already said about who we are in Christ (Ephesians 1–3)? The armour is for people already secure in him.
- How does the setting of John 8:31–36 deepen your understanding of "the truth will set you free"?
  Guide: Jesus speaks of freedom from slavery to sin, for those who abide in his word; it is the Son who sets us free (John 8:36).

- What helped Kevin, and what helped Aaron, to stop hiding?
  Guide: Example: telling the truth to trusted people and receiving their help. Follow up: who could you be honest with? Answers can stay private.

The other story (for the practical activity, or for leaders' preparation)

Aaron's story (from Chapter 5): *Imagine a youth pastor named Aaron.* For years he has given everything: late-night phone calls, weekend camps, extra Bible studies. His answer to every problem is to try harder, pray longer and do more. One evening, sitting in his car outside the church, he prays, "Lord, I don't have anything left." Then he does something he has avoided for months: he tells two older leaders the truth about how tired he is. They pray for him, help him share the load and encourage him to take proper rest. He learns that standing firm was never meant to be a one-man effort.

Session 5 · The Breastplate of Righteousness and the Shoes of Peace

Lesson 5 · Chapters 7–8

Question	What steadies my heart when I feel accused or unsettled?
Central truth	We stand on what Christ has given — his righteousness and peace with God — and we carry that peace to others.
Principal passage	Ephesians 6:14–15 (the lesson's verses are 6:14b–15; the reading starts at "Stand therefore" to retain the command and its context)
Three main points	(1) The breastplate: righteousness received, then lived · (2) The gospel of peace gives us firm ground · (3) Ready to carry the gospel of peace
This week's practice	Write a few sentences on why you follow Jesus, beginning "Because Christ has made me right with God, I have peace with him, and…", and share them with a trusted believer

Don't miss this

- Both pieces of armour describe what God gives before they describe what we do. The righteousness that protects us begins with God himself (Isaiah 59:17).
- Righteousness received and righteousness lived are never confused and never separated: we live rightly because we have been accepted, not in order to be accepted (2 Corinthians 5:21; Ephesians 4:24; Romans 6:1–2).
- Romans 8:33–34 answers accusation by pointing to God and to Christ, not to our record. A real wrong still calls for an apology and repair, made from security rather than fear.
- "Readiness" can be heard as firm footing or as readiness to go; the lesson keeps both and puts the weight on the source: the gospel of peace gives us firm ground and prepares us to carry good news.
- The robe in Luke 15:22 illustrates welcome given rather than earned; it is not used to define the breastplate.
- Feeling anxious or unsettled does not mean that you have lost your peace with God.
- Peace with God is not the absence of trouble (John 16:33).

- Readiness to share the gospel is a conversation, with gentleness and respect (1 Peter 3:15), not an attack.

Purpose of the session: to help believers rest in the righteousness Christ gives and the peace with God he has made, and to leave ready to explain their faith simply and gently.

Central Scripture and context: Ephesians 6:14–15. The breastplate and the shoes describe what God gives before what we do. Isaiah 59:17 shows God wearing righteousness first; Romans 5:1 names the peace with God through which the gospel of peace gives believers firm ground.

60-minute plan

Minutes	Activity
0–5	Welcome and prayer
5–25	Watch Lesson 5 together. If everyone has watched it beforehand, use this time instead to read Ephesians 6:14–15 and Romans 8:31–39 aloud, and discuss the three main points.
25–40	Discussion: the three Talk about it questions
40–52	Practical activity: in pairs, anyone who wishes can try the sentence starter aloud — "Because Christ has made me right with God, I have peace with him, and…" — and receive one encouragement from their partner. Sharing is optional.
52–58	Read Somchai's story aloud (Go Deeper: "Somchai finds his footing") and ask: what helped him answer "with gentleness and respect"?
58–60	Closing prayer (the lesson's prayer)

Prepare: watch Lesson 5. "Somchai finds his footing" is on the lesson page under Go Deeper and printed at the end of this session.

Facilitator guidance: keep the order of grace clear: received first, then lived. If anyone hears the lesson as "how I live does not matter", return to Romans 6:1–2. If anyone hears it as "I must earn God's approval", return to Romans 8:33–34 and the father's welcome in Luke 15.

Common misunderstandings and pastoral responses

- "If I'm accepted, my behaviour doesn't matter." → Grace does not make holiness optional; it makes holiness possible (Romans 6:1–2).
- "God's approval rises and falls with how I did this week." → Our standing rests on Christ (2 Corinthians 5:21; Romans 8:33–34).
- "Peace means avoiding every disagreement." → Jesus is the Prince of Peace and still spoke the truth; we seek peace as far as it depends on us.
- "Standing firm means winning every argument about faith." → We share the gospel with gentleness and respect (1 Peter 3:15).

Following up next week: ask, "Did you write your few sentences, and were you able to share them?" No one is asked to read theirs aloud.

Talk about it (the three discussion questions, each with a one-line guide)

- Why is it important that our standing with God comes first, and our way of life grows out of it?
  Guide: Return to Ephesians 2:8–10: we live rightly because we have been accepted, not in order to be accepted.
- What is the difference between seeking peace and simply avoiding every disagreement?
  Guide: Follow up: when might making peace require an honest conversation rather than silence? (Romans 12:18)
- How might the way we share our faith either match or contradict the gospel of peace?
  Guide: Look at Somchai's story: gentleness and respect (1 Peter 3:15) fit the message of peace we carry.

The other story (for the practical activity, or for leaders' preparation)

Somchai finds his footing (Chapter 8's story, shortened): *Imagine a young man named Somchai, the first person in his family to follow Jesus. At festival times the tension grows, and whenever he tries to explain his faith the conversation becomes an argument. An older Christian who also came to faith from a family of another religion advises him to honour his parents in every way he can with a clear conscience, to help at home, to be patient, and to answer simply and kindly when they ask. Over the next months Somchai stops trying to win every argument. The tension does not disappear. But one evening his mother quietly asks, "What is it about Jesus that matters so much to you?" This time, Somchai is ready, and he answers with gentleness.* (Where family pressure becomes threatening or coercive, it is right to seek help from trusted church leaders and, where needed, from others who can protect you.)

Session 6 · The Shield of Faith and the Helmet of Salvation

Lesson 6 · Chapters 9–10

Question	How do I keep trusting God when the outcome is still uncertain?
Central truth	Faith in God and the hope of salvation hold us even when the outcome is uncertain.
Principal passage	Ephesians 6:16–17a (the reading ends at "the helmet of salvation"; the sword of the Spirit is Lesson 7)
Three main points	(1) The shield: faith in God, not faith in faith · (2) Faith when the outcome is uncertain · (3) The helmet: salvation past, present and future, and the hope it gives
This week's practice	Write down one doubt that keeps returning, and a promise from Scripture beside it; then write a short prayer asking honestly for what you need, while trusting God without demanding a particular result or timetable

Don't miss this

- The shield of faith is faith in God, not faith in faith. Its strength depends on the One we trust; small, trembling faith is still a real shield (Mark 9:24).
- We do not need to establish the source of every flaming dart before answering it with God's Word.
- Hebrews 11 commends both those who saw deliverance and those who did not. Continuing hardship does not mean failed faith.

- Faith trusts what God has promised without insisting on an outcome he has not guaranteed; God's promises are sure, and our own expectations are held more humbly.
- Salvation has three tenses: we have been saved, are being saved and will be saved.
- Assurance rests on Christ, not on the strength of our feelings; Christian hope rests on the resurrection, not on positive thinking.

Purpose of the session: to help believers keep trusting God through long, unresolved seasons, to answer recurring doubts with God's promises, and to rest their assurance and hope on Christ.

Central Scripture and context: Ephesians 6:16–17a. The shield of faith is trust in God himself, able to extinguish the flaming darts of the evil one. The helmet of salvation is "the hope of salvation" (1 Thessalonians 5:8), resting on Christ who died for us. Hebrews 11:32–40 shows that faith is commended whether or not deliverance comes in this life.

60-minute plan

Minutes	Activity
0–5	Welcome and prayer
5–25	Watch Lesson 6 together. If everyone has watched it beforehand, use this time instead to read Ephesians 6:16–17 and Hebrews 11:32–40 aloud, and discuss the three main points.
25–40	Discussion: the three Talk about it questions
40–52	Practical activity: as a group, list on a large sheet some promises God has truly made (his presence, care, forgiveness, faithfulness) and some outcomes he has not guaranteed (a particular job, timing or result). Ask: how does this help us pray with confidence and humility? Then read the example prayer from the practice together: "Father, please provide work for our family. Help us take wise steps and trust your care while we wait." Specific requests are welcome; we bring them while trusting God without demanding a particular result or timetable. No one is asked to share a personal doubt.
52–58	Read Marcus's story aloud (Go Deeper: "Marcus's story") and 1 John 5:11–13. Ask: where did Marcus learn to look for assurance?
58–60	Closing prayer (the lesson's prayer)

Prepare: watch Lesson 6. "Marcus's story" is on the lesson page under Go Deeper and printed at the end of this session.

Facilitator guidance: keep the shield and the helmet focused on God's character and promises, not on the strength of our feelings. If anyone suggests that a lack of answered prayer shows a lack of faith, return to Hebrews 11:39–40. If anyone is grieving or has gone through a long, hard season, listen first and avoid quick answers, as Esi's small group did. Offer to pray with them, and follow up afterwards.

Common misunderstandings and pastoral responses

- “If I had enough faith, God would give me what I am asking.” → Faith trusts what God has promised without insisting on an outcome he has not guaranteed (Hebrews 11:39–40).
- “My doubts mean my faith has failed.” → Jesus helped the father who said, “I believe; help my unbelief!” (Mark 9:24).
- “Assurance means I can live however I like.” → Assurance encourages grateful obedience (1 John 2:6).
- “Hope means I should not grieve.” → We grieve, but not as those who have no hope (1 Thessalonians 4:13).

Following up next week: ask, “Did you write down a doubt and a promise beside it, and a short prayer asking God honestly for what you need?” Sharing is optional.

Talk about it (the three discussion questions, each with a one-line guide)

- What kinds of “flaming darts” might a believer face, and how could the group help?
  Guide: Examples: doubt, accusation, fear, temptation. Keep the answers general; no one needs to describe their own struggle.
- Why do you think Hebrews 11 commends both those who saw deliverance and those who did not?
  Guide: Read Hebrews 11:32–40. Continuing hardship does not mean failed faith.
- What is the difference between Christian hope and positive thinking?
  Guide: Christian hope rests on the resurrection and on what God has promised (1 Peter 1:3), not on our own expectations.

The other story (for the practical activity, or for leaders’ preparation)

Marcus’s story (from Chapter 10): *Imagine a man named Marcus.* He has been a Christian for more than twenty years. Last spring his father died after a long illness, and since then Marcus has lain awake thinking about death, wondering whether he is really saved, and feeling that the future looks grey. He finally tells his pastor, who does not hurry him or dismiss his grief. They read through 1 John together slowly, and Marcus begins to see that his assurance rests on Christ, not on how strong he feels. His pastor also encourages him to see his doctor about his sleep and to join a small grief group at the church. Marcus still misses his father, and some nights are still hard. But hope becomes something he can hold on to again, even with tears.

Session 7 · The Sword of the Spirit and Praying at All Times

Lesson 7 · Chapters 11–12

Question	How do I use God’s Word and prayer in the battle?
Central truth	God’s Word and prayer are how we stand, and how we help others stand.
Principal passage	Ephesians 6:17b–20 (from “the sword of the Spirit” to “as I ought to speak”)
Three main points	(1) The sword of the Spirit: the Word given by the Spirit, as Jesus used it · (2) Praying at all times in the Spirit · (3) Keep alert, for all the saints
This week’s practice	Choose one verse for your current struggle. Each day, read it in its context and turn it into a short prayer for yourself and for one other believer.

Don’t miss this

- The sword of the Spirit is the Word of God, given by the Spirit; it is not our own opinion, a weapon against people or a charm.
- God's Word searches our own hearts before it equips us to resist deception (Hebrews 4:12), and it points us to grace.
- Jesus used Scripture he knew in its setting, and he prayed the Psalms on the cross: the Word is for hard hours as well as victories.
- Prayer is not another piece of armour. Many interpreters see it as the way the whole armour is worn: at all times, in dependence on the Spirit.
- Christians differ on whether praying in the Spirit includes praying in tongues. This course holds that tongues is a genuine gift and should not be forbidden, while praying in the Spirit is never limited to tongues and no believer's prayers are second-class.
- Keeping alert means watchful, persevering prayer for all the saints, including prayer for boldness to make Christ known.

Purpose of the session: to help believers take up God's Word with understanding, pray at all times in dependence on the Spirit, and pray for one another.

Central Scripture and context: Ephesians 6:17b–20. The sword of the Spirit is the word of God, given by the Spirit and used by Jesus in temptation. Prayer is not another piece of armour; many interpreters see it as the way the whole armour is worn: at all times, in the Spirit, alert and persevering, for all the saints, and for boldness in the gospel.

60-minute plan

Minutes	Activity
0–5	Welcome and prayer
5–25	Watch Lesson 7 together. If everyone has watched it beforehand, use this time instead to read Ephesians 6:17–20 and Matthew 4:1–11 aloud, and discuss the three main points.
25–40	Discussion: the three Talk about it questions
40–52	Practical activity: as a group, read one short passage (for example Psalm 46:1–3) and work through the three questions together. Then, in pairs, anyone who wishes turns one verse into a short prayer for a believer they know, using "Lord, you have said… so I ask you…". Read the example first (based on Romans 8:26): "Father, your Spirit helps us in our weakness. Help me and my friend pray when we do not know what to say." Sharing is optional.
52–58	Read Joy's story aloud (Go Deeper: "Joy's story"). Ask: how did God's Word first speak to Joy herself, before it shaped how she responded to others?
58–60	Closing prayer (the lesson's prayer)

Activity materials: three questions for reading a passage

1. What is happening in this passage?
2. What does it reveal about God and his work?

3. What response does it call for?

Only then ask how it applies to us. Then turn one verse into prayer: "Lord, you have said… so I ask you… for me and for…"

Prepare: watch Lesson 7. Have Psalm 46:1–3 and the three questions, above, ready. "Joy's story" is on the lesson page under Go Deeper and printed at the end of this session.

Facilitator guidance: keep the discussion of tongues warm and fair. Explain both readings as the lesson does in "Christians differ: praying in tongues", state the course's position plainly, and make sure that no one leaves feeling that their prayers are second-class. If questions go further, offer to talk afterwards or to point people to the church's pastor. Encourage those who find the Bible hard to begin with a short passage and the three questions, and to read with someone else.

Common misunderstandings and pastoral responses

- "The sword is for using against people who are wrong." → We do not wrestle against flesh and blood; the Word searches our own hearts first (Hebrews 4:12).
- "Reciting verses has power in itself." → The power is in the truth of what God has said and the work of the Spirit, received by understanding, believing and obeying it.
- "Effective prayer needs the right words or length." → Your Father knows what you need before you ask him (Matthew 6:8).
- "Praying in the Spirit is only for people with special gifts." → Every believer has received the Spirit and is invited to pray in dependence on him.

Following up next week: ask, "Which verse did you choose, and who did you pray for?" Sharing is optional.

Talk about it (the three discussion questions, each with a one-line guide)

- How has God's Word exposed something in your own heart, and then pointed you to grace?
  Guide: Return to Hebrews 4:12–16: the Word searches us, then points us to a merciful high priest. Sharing is optional.
- How would you explain praying "in the Spirit" to someone with questions like Ama's?
  Guide: Present both readings fairly, as the lesson does. Follow up: what did the older woman tell Ama? ("Start where you are.")
- What do you notice about Paul's request for prayer while he was in chains?
  Guide: Read Ephesians 6:19–20: Paul asked for boldness to make the gospel known.

The other story (for the practical activity, or for leaders' preparation)

Joy's story (from Chapter 11): *Imagine a woman named Joy.* She came to faith three years ago, not long after a painful divorce, and one struggle keeps returning: bitterness towards her former husband. She finds the Bible hard to read and feels guilty about it. Then she joins a women's Bible study that reads one short passage each week. When the group studies Ephesians 4:31–32, Joy writes verse 32 on a card and keeps it by her phone: "Be kind to one another, tenderhearted, forgiving one another, as God in Christ forgave you." When the next difficult message comes, she reads it before replying. Some days she still feels angry, but slowly the Word begins to shape how she responds. Forgiveness does not mean pretending nothing happened or removing every boundary; a wise friend helps her communicate calmly for the sake of her children. The Word does not make her situation simple, but it gives her a different way to stand in it.

Session 8 · Is This a Spiritual Attack?

Lesson 8 · Chapter 13

Question	How do I test spiritual claims and respond wisely when life is difficult?
Central truth	We test every spiritual claim by Christ and Scripture, and we can respond faithfully without being certain of the cause.
Principal passage	1 John 4:1–3, read in its setting
Three main points	(1) What John was talking about: testing teachers by their confession of Christ · (2) Testing spiritual claims today, including fear of curses · (3) Why certainty about the cause is often unnecessary: the four questions and wise counsel
This week's practice	Take one spiritual claim that troubles you to your pastor or a mature believer, and test it together

Don't miss this

- 1 John 4:1–3 is first about testing teachers by their confession of Christ, not about identifying the cause of every difficulty.
- Christians should not despise prophecy, and they should not believe every spiritual claim; everything is tested by Christ and Scripture (1 Thessalonians 5:20–21).
- Five questions help: the gospel, the fruit over time, money, God's people and Christ himself. An immediate feeling of comfort or fear is not enough.
- Believers need not live in fear of curses; Proverbs 26:2 is a proverb, not a formula, and believers belong to Christ (Colossians 2:15; Romans 8:38–39).
- The four questions from Lesson 1 are reflection prompts, not a test that diagnoses a difficulty; more than one answer is often true at once.
- Wise counsel protects us from two opposite errors: dismissing real spiritual opposition, and seeing it behind everything.

Purpose of the session: to help believers test spiritual claims by Christ and Scripture, to reassure those who fear curses that they belong to Christ, and to respond faithfully to hardship without needing to be certain of its cause.

Central Scripture and context: 1 John 4:1–3. John wrote to churches troubled by false teachers who had left the fellowship (1 John 2:19). The test he gives is about Christ: the confession "that Jesus Christ has come in the flesh". From there we draw the wider principle of 1 Thessalonians 5:20–21: do not despise prophecy, but test everything and hold fast what is good.

60-minute plan

Minutes	Activity
0–5	Welcome and prayer
5–25	Watch Lesson 8 together. If everyone has watched it beforehand, use this time instead to read 1 John 4:1–6 and 1 John 2:18–19 aloud, and discuss the three main points.
25–40	Discussion: the three Talk about it questions
40–52	Practical activity: the leader reads aloud a made-up

Minutes	Activity
	spiritual claim (for example, “God has told me that everyone who gives to my ministry this week will be protected from sickness”). As a group, test it with the five questions and say whether it should be accepted, questioned or rejected, and why. Do not use any real person’s name or message.
52–58	Read Romans 8:31–39 aloud slowly. Ask: what difference does belonging to Christ make for someone afraid of a curse?
58–60	Closing prayer (the lesson’s prayer)

Activity materials: the five questions for testing a spiritual claim

1. Does it agree with the gospel?
2. What is its fruit?
3. Is money involved in a troubling way?
4. Does it draw me towards God’s people?
5. Does it bring me to Christ?

These questions help us assess a claim. Passing them does not, by itself, prove that a particular prediction or message came from God.

Prepare: watch Lesson 8. Prepare the made-up claim for the activity, and have the five questions, above, ready to read aloud.

Facilitator guidance: take people’s fears seriously, and do not laugh at them, as Tunde’s pastor did not. Avoid naming or criticising particular preachers or churches in the group; test messages, not people’s hearts. If a claim comes from someone’s own pastor or church leader, encourage them gently: If the claim comes from your own leader, seek counsel from another trustworthy Christian who can assess it independently. If someone shares a specific fear or a specific claim made about them, offer to talk and pray with them afterwards, and help them think through any practical needs, as the pastor helped Tunde.

Common misunderstandings and pastoral responses

- “A mature Christian can always tell whether something is an attack.” → Scripture rarely asks us to diagnose causes with certainty; it asks us to test claims, walk in truth, resist fear and act faithfully.
- “Testing a prophecy shows a lack of faith.” → Testing is obedience to Scripture: “test everything; hold fast what is good.”
- “Proverbs 26:2 tells me how to know whether I am cursed.” → It is a proverb, not a formula; believers belong to Christ.
- “If it made me feel peaceful, it must be from God.” → An immediate feeling of comfort or fear is not enough; look at the gospel, the fruit over time and where it leads.

Following up next week: ask, “Did you test a claim with someone? What did you find?” Sharing is optional.

Talk about it (the three discussion questions, each with a one-line guide)

- Why do you think fear-driven spiritual messages can feel so convincing?
  Guide: Follow up: what does fear push us to do quickly? Return to Romans 8:38–39: nothing can separate us from the love of God in Christ.

- Which of the five questions would have helped Tunde most, and why?
  Guide: Any question can be the answer; ask for the reason. Remember that passing the questions does not, by itself, prove a message came from God.
- How can a church help people test spiritual claims without becoming suspicious of everything?
  Guide: Return to 1 Thessalonians 5:20–21: do not despise prophecy, but test everything and hold fast what is good.

Session 9 · Submit, Resist and Worship

Lesson 9 · Chapters 14–15

Question	What do I do when the battle does not end quickly?
Central truth	We stand by submitting to God, resisting the devil and worshipping, even when the battle is long.
Principal passage	James 4:6–10
Three main points	(1) Submission comes first, then resistance · (2) When the battle does not end quickly · (3) Worship as trust: "Our eyes are on you" (fasting mentioned briefly as humbling ourselves before God)
This week's practice	Name one faithful response to the struggle you are facing: one way to submit to God and one way to stand against the enemy there. Then set aside one time this week to worship God before you ask him for anything.

Don't miss this

- In James 4, submission comes before resistance: in its setting, submitting to God means humbling ourselves and turning from pride.
- Resisting means standing against the enemy: refusing his lies, refusing him an opportunity and refusing to give up. The authority belongs to Christ, not to our technique (Jude 9).
- "He will flee" is a real promise, but the battle may return: the devil left Jesus "until an opportune time" (Luke 4:13). We resist again.
- When the battle does not end quickly, we keep praying, and God gives grace while we wait (2 Corinthians 12:9).
- 2 Chronicles 20 carries a specific promise to Judah; we draw lasting principles from it: turning to God, humbling ourselves together, praying honestly, listening for God's word and worshipping before we see the outcome.
- Worship can include lament; fasting is voluntary, a way of humbling ourselves, never a way of forcing God's hand.

Purpose of the session: to help believers stand in long struggles by humbling themselves before God, resisting the devil in the strength Christ gives, receiving grace while they wait, and worshipping before they see the outcome.

Central Scripture and context: James 4:6–10. James writes to believers caught up in quarrels and pride; "Submit yourselves therefore to God" comes before "Resist the devil". 2 Chronicles 20 shows God's people turning to him in fear, humbling themselves together and worshipping before the outcome. It carries a specific promise to Judah, from which we draw lasting principles.

60-minute plan

Minutes	Activity
0–5	Welcome and prayer
5–25	Watch Lesson 9 together. If everyone has watched it beforehand, use this time instead to read James 4:1–10 and 2 Chronicles 20:1–22 aloud, and discuss the three main points.
25–40	Discussion: the three Talk about it questions
40–52	Practical activity: read Carmen's story aloud (Go Deeper: "Carmen's story"). Then spend a few minutes worshipping together before praying for any needs: read Psalm 42 aloud, or sing a song that declares God's steadfast love. Afterwards ask: what was it like to worship before asking? Sharing is optional.
52–58	In pairs, anyone who wishes names one way to humble themselves before God and one way to stand against the enemy in a struggle they are facing. Pray for one another briefly.
58–60	Closing prayer (the lesson's prayer)

Prepare: watch Lesson 9. "Carmen's story" is on the lesson page under Go Deeper and printed at the end of this session. Have Psalm 42 ready.

Facilitator guidance: keep the order clear: submission before resistance. If anyone has been told that their continuing struggle shows weak faith, return to 2 Corinthians 12:9. If the group plans to fast together, make it voluntary and private, as Carmen's church did; no one should be asked how much they have fasted.

Common misunderstandings and pastoral responses

- "If I rebuke the enemy loudly enough, the problem must go." → The authority belongs to Christ, not to our technique (Jude 9); resistance is joined to humility and faith.
- "If the temptation returns, my resistance failed." → After the wilderness temptations, the devil left Jesus until an opportune time. When temptation returns, we can resist again. (Luke 4:13)
- "If we worship enough, every problem will disappear." → 2 Chronicles 20 carries a specific promise to Judah; worship is trust, not a technique.
- "Submitting to God means accepting whatever happens." → We submit to God and resist the devil (James 4:7).

Following up next week: ask, "Were you able to name a faithful response, and to worship before you asked?" Sharing is optional.

Talk about it (the three discussion questions, each with a one-line guide)

- What does Ephesians 4:26–27 teach about how we can give the enemy an opportunity?
  Guide: Anger left unresolved can become a foothold. The answer is not to deny anger but to deal with it promptly (v. 26).
- Why is it important to distinguish the specific promise in 2 Chronicles 20 from the lasting principles we can learn?

Guide: The promise of victory was given to Judah; the lasting principles are turning to God, humbling ourselves together, praying and worshipping.

- How can worship be honest when we are struggling?
  Guide: Point to the psalms of lament, such as Psalm 42: honest sorrow and hope in God belong together.

The other story (for the practical activity, or for leaders' preparation)

Carmen's story (from Chapter 15): *Imagine a woman named Carmen.* She leads worship at a small church going through a painful season: the pastor's wife is seriously ill, several families have left after a disagreement, and Sunday gatherings feel heavy. Carmen wonders whether it is dishonest to praise God when she feels like this. The pastor calls the church to a week of prayer and voluntary fasting, ending with an evening of worship; each person takes part in the way that suits them, and no one is asked how much they have fasted. They read 2 Chronicles 20 together and pray, "We do not know what to do, but our eyes are on you." On the final evening, Carmen's voice breaks more than once as they sing, "His love endures forever." The weeks that follow are still hard, and the church keeps praying for the pastor's wife. But two families come back to talk, the leaders begin listening to those who were hurt, and a meal rota begins for the pastor's family. Carmen finds she can lead worship again, not because everything has been resolved, but because she has remembered who God is.

Session 10 · Together and Free

Lesson 10 · Chapters 16–17

Question	What freedom do I have in Christ, and who will walk in it with me?
Central truth	Every believer belongs to Christ and is free in him, and we walk in that freedom with trustworthy believers.
Principal passage	Galatians 5:1, 13
Three main points	(1) The freedom every believer has in Christ (Galatians 5:1, kept distinct from Mark 5) · (2) We do not walk alone: a church that prays together · (3) Walking in freedom: turning from the old ways, and how prayer for freedom is done (taught briefly)
This week's practice	Take one step towards a trustworthy believer or church connection.

Don't miss this

- In its setting, Galatians 5:1 is about freedom from trying to earn our standing with God. That freedom belongs to every believer through faith in Christ (Colossians 1:13; Romans 8:1).
- Mark 5 shows Christ's complete authority and the dignity he restores. It is an extraordinary account, not the pattern for every struggle, and it is kept distinct from Galatians 5.
- Christians differ about some aspects of spiritual oppression and prayer for freedom; our focus is belonging to Christ and walking faithfully with trustworthy believers.
- The church in Acts 4 went to their friends, prayed together, asked for boldness and cared for one another.

- Turning from the old ways (Acts 19) follows a helpful pattern: confess, renounce, let go, walk on. Letting go is never a ritual that buys protection; it is a choice to stop relying on those things, by someone who already belongs to Christ.
- Prayer for freedom is done with consent, with dignity and with at least two mature leaders under your church's care. Prayer and medical care go together; never stop treatment.

Purpose of the session: to help believers rest in the freedom they have in Christ, and to take one step towards walking in it with trustworthy believers.

Central Scripture and context: Galatians 5:1, 13. Paul writes to Gentile believers who were being told they must keep the law of Moses to be right with God. The freedom he defends is freedom from trying to earn our standing with God, and it is lived out in love for one another. Acts 4:23–31 shows a church under pressure going to one another and praying together.

60-minute plan

Minutes	Activity
0–5	Welcome and prayer
5–25	Watch Lesson 10 together. If everyone has watched it beforehand, use this time instead to read Galatians 5:1–16 and Acts 4:23–35 aloud, and discuss the three main points.
25–40	Discussion: the three Talk about it questions
40–52	Practical activity: read Felix's story aloud (Go Deeper: "Felix's story"). Then pray together in the pattern of Acts 4: begin with who God is, read a short passage of Scripture, and ask God for boldness. Sharing is optional.
52–58	In pairs, anyone who wishes names one step they will take towards a trustworthy believer or church connection this week. Pray for one another briefly.
58–60	Closing prayer (the lesson's prayer)

Prepare: watch Lesson 10. "Felix's story" is on the lesson page under Go Deeper and printed at the end of this session.

Facilitator guidance: keep Galatians 5 and Mark 5 distinct. Welcome newcomers warmly, and make sure no one in the group is left on their own. If someone shares past occult involvement, listen without alarm, remind them that they belong to Christ (Colossians 1:13), and connect them with a pastor.

Christians differ (fuller note): Scripture describes believers facing temptation, accusation and spiritual opposition. Christians differ over whether a believer can experience demonic influence beyond temptation and accusation, and over when focused prayer for freedom is appropriate. Some believe it can be; others are more cautious. These differences must not displace the assurance that believers belong to Christ (Romans 8:38–39).

Mark 5 and former occult involvement: Mark 5:1–20 shows Christ's complete authority and the dignity, peace and purpose he restores. It is an extraordinary account and should not be made the pattern for every struggle. For those with past involvement in practices that oppose God, Acts 19:18–20 suggests a helpful pattern: confess, renounce, let go (voluntarily, of items the person owns and used for occult practice or

protection; ordinary cultural and family belongings are not in view; the person already belongs to Christ, and letting go is one way they choose to stop relying on those things) and walk on in discipleship.

When someone requests focused prayer for freedom: consent (the person freely agrees and can stop at any time); dignity (no shouting, restraint, public exposure or recording); confidentiality (within the requirements of safeguarding law); accountability (at least two mature leaders, under the oversight of their church: a wise safeguard rather than a biblical requirement); follow-up (ongoing discipleship, fellowship and care); openness to other help (medical and professional care are welcomed alongside prayer; those praying do not diagnose illness or advise anyone to stop prescribed treatment).

Matthew 16:18–19: Christians have understood "this rock" in different ways: as Peter, as Peter's confession, or as Christ. "Bind" and "loose" concern Christ's authority in the matters of his kingdom, given to Peter and exercised among his gathered people (compare Matthew 18:15–20). They are not a formula for addressing spirits.

Common misunderstandings and pastoral responses

- "Galatians 5:1 means I need a deliverance meeting." → In its setting, it is about freedom from earning our standing with God; every believer has this freedom in Christ.
- "Nightmares or dread prove I am under oppression." → By themselves, they do not; they call for prayer, wisdom and, where needed, medical care.
- "Getting rid of an object will protect me." → It is not a ritual that buys protection. A believer already belongs to Christ; letting go is one way of choosing to stop relying on those things.
- "I don't need church; my faith is between me and God." → Even the apostles went to their friends and prayed together (Acts 4:23–24).

Following up next week: ask, "Were you able to take a step towards a trustworthy believer or church connection?" Sharing is optional.

Talk about it (the three discussion questions, each with a one-line guide)

- What is the difference between the freedom Paul describes in Galatians 5:1 and the deliverance described in Mark 5?
  Guide: Galatians 5:1 describes the freedom every believer has in Christ; Mark 5 is an extraordinary account of his authority, not the pattern for every struggle.
- What can we learn from the way the believers prayed together in Acts 4?
  Guide: Read Acts 4:23–31: they went to their friends, began with who God is, used Scripture and asked for boldness.
- Who in your church could you stand with, and who could stand with you?
  Guide: Answers can stay private. Encourage each person to think of one name before next week.

The other story (for the practical activity, or for leaders' preparation)

Felix's story (from Chapter 16): *Imagine a young man named Felix*. He came to faith as a teenager in a lively youth group. Two years ago he moved to a new city for work. The first church he visited felt unfriendly, and after that he never quite got round to finding another. Now he watches sermons online on Sunday mornings, when he remembers. His faith feels thin, he is lonely, and late at night he finds himself returning to habits he thought he had left behind. When a friend from home asks whether he has found a church, Felix says, "I don't really need one. My faith is between me and God." But his friend keeps encouraging him, and Felix tries another church. An older couple invites him for lunch, and a few weeks later he joins a small group that meets on Wednesday evenings. After some months he trusts one of the men enough to tell him about the habits he has been struggling with. The man does not condemn him. He prays with him, checks in during the

week and helps him put practical boundaries in place. Felix still has hard days, and some nights are still lonely. But he is no longer fighting alone, and he begins helping with the church's welcome team, looking out for newcomers who, like him, might otherwise slip away.

Session 11 · Guarding Your Heart and Passing Faith On

Lesson 11 · Chapters 18–19

Question	How do I keep my heart, and help someone else's faith grow?
Central truth	We guard our hearts in Christ, and a guarded heart helps another person's faith grow.
Principal passage	Proverbs 4:20–27
Three main points	(1) What the Bible means by "heart", and how hearts drift · (2) Rhythms that keep the heart, faithful over the long haul · (3) Passing faith on: parenting, mentoring, friendship and service in the church
This week's practice	Choose one daily rhythm that guards your heart, and keep it all week. Then name one person whose faith you can encourage.

Don't miss this

- In Scripture the heart (*lēb*) is the inner centre of a person: where we think, desire, decide and trust. From it flow "the springs of life" (Proverbs 4:23).
- Guarding the heart involves the whole person: ears, mouth, eyes and feet.
- Hearts usually drift gradually: through neglect, nursed resentment, isolation and small compromises. Long years of faith do not make us immune (1 Corinthians 10:12).
- We guard our hearts with vigilance, not fear: it is God's peace that guards our hearts (Philippians 4:7).
- Passing faith on begins with our own love for God (Deuteronomy 6:5–7), happens in ordinary moments, and includes parenting, mentoring, friendship and service in the church.
- Proverbs 22:6 is a proverb, not an unconditional guarantee. We are called to be faithful, not to control the outcome.

Purpose of the session: to help believers keep their hearts through ordinary rhythms of grace, and to encourage the faith of someone younger or newer in the faith.

Central Scripture and context: Proverbs 4:20–27. A father urges his son to keep his heart, the inner centre from which life flows, and to guard his ears, mouth, eyes and feet. Deuteronomy 6:4–9 shows that passing faith on begins with our own love for God and happens in ordinary moments. In 2 Timothy 1:5, Paul remembers the sincere faith of Lois and Eunice and recognises it in Timothy.

60-minute plan

Minutes	Activity
0–5	Welcome and prayer
5–25	Watch Lesson 11 together. If everyone has watched it beforehand, use this time instead to read

Minutes	Activity
	Proverbs 4:20–27 and Deuteronomy 6:4–9 aloud, and discuss the three main points.
25–40	Discussion: the three Talk about it questions
40–52	Practical activity: read Kwame and Efua's story aloud (Go Deeper: "Kwame and Efua's story"). Then invite anyone who wishes to share briefly, in one or two sentences, a story of God's faithfulness they could tell a younger believer. Sharing is optional.
52–58	In pairs, anyone who wishes names one daily rhythm they will keep this week and one person whose faith they will encourage. Pray for one another briefly.
58–60	Closing prayer (the lesson's prayer)

Prepare: watch Lesson 11. "Kwame and Efua's story" is on the lesson page under Go Deeper and printed at the end of this session.

Facilitator guidance: keep the tone hopeful: drift is common, and turning back is always possible. If someone is grieving a child or family member who has wandered, return to Luke 15:20 and assure them that faithfulness, not control, is their calling. Parents of young children can be encouraged that ordinary moments matter more than perfect devotions.

Proverbs 22:6 (fuller note): proverbs describe how life generally works under God; they are not unconditional promises. Each child must come to faith personally. Parents who have been faithful should not carry false guilt when a child wanders, and should keep praying and showing love, with wise boundaries where needed.

Children and spiritual fears: start with Jesus (1 John 4:4); speak simply and calmly; give children words to pray (Psalm 4:8); do not confirm every frightening story, and help them see that bad dreams and scary feelings are not always signs of something sinister.

Common misunderstandings and pastoral responses

- "After many years of faith, I'm safe from drifting." → "Let anyone who thinks that he stands take heed lest he fall" (1 Corinthians 10:12); experience is a gift, not a substitute for daily dependence on God.
- "Guarding my heart means constant anxious self-examination." → It is vigilance rooted in trust; God's peace guards our hearts (Philippians 4:7).
- "Passing on faith is the church's job." → Scripture places it in everyday family life, supported by the wider church (Deuteronomy 6:7).
- "If I train my children well, they are guaranteed to follow God." → Proverbs 22:6 is a proverb, not a guarantee; we are called to be faithful, not to control the outcome.

Following up next week: ask, "Were you able to keep a daily rhythm, and to encourage someone's faith?" Sharing is optional.

Talk about it (the three discussion questions, each with a one-line guide)

- How does Philippians 4:6–7 help us guard our hearts without anxiety?
  Guide: It is God's peace that guards our hearts. Follow up: what is one worry you could bring to God in prayer this week?
- What ordinary moments in your week could become opportunities to talk about faith?
  Guide: Return to Deuteronomy 6:7: at home, on the way, at bedtime and in the morning. Examples: meals, journeys, a text message.
- What would it look like for you to be faithful over the long haul?
  Guide: Examples: daily rhythms, honest friendships, turning back quickly when we drift. We are called to be faithful, not to control the outcome.

The other story (for the practical activity, or for leaders' preparation)

Kwame and Efua's story (from Chapter 19): *Imagine a couple named Kwame and Efua.* They have two children. Their eight-year-old daughter, Akosua, heard frightening stories from her cousins about witches and evil spirits, and now she is afraid to sleep with the light off. Their fifteen-year-old son, Kojo, has grown quiet about his faith; last week he asked, "How do we even know any of this is true?" Kwame and Efua begin praying with Akosua each night before she sleeps. Efua teaches her Psalm 4:8, and they gently explain that frightening stories are not always true, and that Jesus is always with her and stronger than anything that frightens her. They listen when she is scared, without making her prove that she is brave. After a few weeks Akosua still likes a small night light, and bedtime has become calmer. With Kojo, Kwame tries a different approach. Instead of lecturing, he asks his son to share his questions, and they agree to look into one each week. Kwame admits he does not know every answer. He also asks Kojo whether he would like to meet with a young man from their church whom he respects, and Kojo agrees. Kojo's questions are not all resolved, but he knows his faith is something he can explore honestly, and that his parents will keep loving him whatever he decides.

Session 12 · Until He Comes: Stand Firm

Lesson 12 · Chapter 20 and Conclusion

Question	What does standing firm look like for the rest of my life?
Central truth	Christ's victory is certain, so we stand, serve and hope, even before relief comes.
Principal passage	Matthew 28:18–20
Three main points	(1) Authority that sends us out: every believer has a part · (2) "They have conquered him": the certain end of the enemy · (3) Having done all, stand, even when relief has not yet come
This week's practice	If you wish, begin My Stand Firm Plan.

Don't miss this

- The risen Jesus has all authority, and he sends his people to make disciples (Matthew 28:18–20). Spiritual warfare is not only defensive.
- Every believer has a part, whatever their age, gifts or energy; the Spirit empowers ordinary people for witness.
- Revelation 12:11: God's people conquer the accuser by the blood of the Lamb and the word of their testimony. Victory in Christ does not always look like escape from suffering.

- Christians differ about the timing of events around Christ's return, but the outcome is not in doubt. We live in hope, not fear.
- "Having done all, to stand firm" (Ephesians 6:13): the goal is faithfulness through the evil day, even when relief has not yet come.
- We are not meant to stand alone: the armour of God was described to a church.

Purpose of the session: to help believers look ahead with hope, find their part in Christ's mission, and, if they wish, begin a simple plan for standing firm with others.

Central Scripture and context: Matthew 28:16–20. On a mountain in Galilee, with some still doubting, the risen Jesus declares that all authority is his, sends his disciples to make disciples of all nations, and promises to be with them always. Revelation 12:11 and Ephesians 6:13 frame the hope and the calling: Christ's victory is certain, and having done all, we stand.

60-minute plan

Minutes	Activity
0–5	Welcome and prayer
5–25	Watch Lesson 12 together. If everyone has watched it beforehand, use this time instead to read Matthew 28:16–20 and Ephesians 6:10–18 aloud, and discuss the three main points.
25–40	Discussion: the three Talk about it questions
40–52	Practical activity: read Rafael's story aloud (Go Deeper: "Rafael's story"). Then allow a few quiet minutes. Anyone who wishes may begin My Stand Firm Plan; others may simply reflect or pray. Writing is optional, and so is sharing a line from it.
52–58	Commissioning: pray for one another in pairs or as a group, using the closing prayer of commissioning on the lesson page.
58–60	Closing blessing (Jude 24–25)

Prepare: watch Lesson 12. "Rafael's story" is on the lesson page under Go Deeper and printed at the end of this session. Have My Stand Firm Plan open, for anyone who wishes to begin it.

Facilitator guidance: this is the last session, so leave room for thanksgiving. Celebrate what God has done in the group over twelve weeks. If anyone is still in a long battle, return to Ephesians 6:13 and 2 Corinthians 4:8–9: continuing to stand is faithfulness, not failure. Encourage the group to keep meeting, or to join another group, so that no one stands alone.

Christians differ (fuller note): Christians differ about the timing and order of the events around Christ's return, and understand many details of Revelation in different ways. The lesson teaches no particular view. What is clear: Christ will return, the enemy's final judgement is certain, and God will make all things new (Revelation 20:10; 21:4).

Common misunderstandings and pastoral responses

- "Spiritual warfare is only about defending ourselves." → Jesus sends his people out; every time the gospel is shared, his kingdom advances (Matthew 28:19; Acts 26:18).

- “I’m too old, too ordinary or too limited to make a difference.” → “They still bear fruit in old age” (Psalm 92:14); praying, encouraging and staying part of the church’s life are real participation.
- “The end times should make me afraid.” → “See that you are not alarmed” (Matthew 24:6); his return is our blessed hope (Titus 2:13).
- “If my struggle continues, I have failed.” → “Having done all, to stand firm” (Ephesians 6:13); continuing to stand is faithfulness.

Following up: if the group continues to meet, ask, “How is your Stand Firm Plan going? Who are you standing with, and who are you helping to stand?” Sharing is optional.

Talk about it (the three discussion questions, each with a one-line guide)

- How does Jesus redirect the disciples from their question about timing towards their calling as witnesses (Acts 1:6–8)?
  Guide: Jesus turns them from the timing of the kingdom to their calling: power from the Spirit, and witness to the ends of the earth.
- What part might God be inviting you to play in his mission in this season of your life?
  Guide: Every believer has a part, whatever their age, gifts or energy. Examples: prayer, hospitality, encouraging a younger believer.
- Who could you share this journey with, so that you are not standing alone?
  Guide: The armour of God was described to a church (Ephesians 6:10–18). Naming someone aloud is optional.

The other story (for the practical activity, or for leaders’ preparation)

Rafael’s story (from Chapter 20): *Imagine a man named Rafael*. He is sixty-four and recently retired after thirty years as a schoolteacher. He has followed Christ since his twenties and served faithfully in his church, but since retiring he has felt unsettled. The news seems full of wars and disasters, and he has started watching online videos claiming that the final days have arrived; the more he watches, the more anxious he becomes. He also feels his useful years are over: “I’m not a pastor or a missionary. I’m just a retired teacher. What difference can I make now?” When he shares his worries with his small group, one member gently suggests that he take a break from the end-times videos and read through Revelation slowly with a good guide instead. Rafael agrees, and finds that the book, read carefully, leaves him with more hope than fear. Around the same time, his church starts a homework club for children from families who have recently arrived in the area. Rafael volunteers, and his years of teaching become a gift once again. Over time, some of the parents begin asking him about his faith, and he shares simply what Christ has done for him. Rafael still prays, “Come, Lord Jesus.” But now he prays it with hope.